luggage hold, which she says she did not want to happen. It was, therefore, not a typical Parsi departure for Soonoo, though Parsi prayers were held at their house even in their absence, recalls Shireen.

Soonoo's ashes were brought to Bombay on 10 October. They had originally planned to immerse them in the Arabian Sea outside the magnificent Gateway of India, where the Tata's iconic Taj Mahal hotel stands. But the waters there were unclean with oil slicks.

The children finally chose the waters north of Raj Bhavan, the official residence of the governor of Maharashtra, to immerse the ashes, as the waters in its vicinity were comparatively clean. On the morning of 27 October, a boat was hired from the Flotilla Club. As the boat neared the sea, Ratan, Jimmy, Shireen and Deanna gently released Soonoo's mortal remains into the fathomless depths of the Arabian Sea.

Picking Up the Pieces

Despite the deep emotional trauma Soonoo's death had caused her children, Ratan never lost his composure, grace and stoicism. He wrote to all the doctors who had treated her, conveying his 'deep thanks and appreciation for everything' that they had done for the 'well-being' of his mother in the hospital, 'as well as the friendship, hospitality and kindness' extended on a 'personal basis' to him and all in the family.

His letter to Dr Edward J. Beattle, the general director and chief operating medical officer of the Memorial Sloan Kettering Cancer Center, was an exemplar of extreme grace under emotionally trying circumstances. He wrote how he was 'endeavouring to pick up [the] pieces' to 'find ways to live around the void' created by the departure of his mother.

His mother's death also opened Ratan's eyes to the lack of medical facilities for cancer patients in India. He realized that a good step in improving the quality of treatment in India would be the establishment of institutional arrangements through which foreign doctors could visit India. With this goal in mind, he addressed Dr Beattle about encouraging the visit of US doctors to Indian hospitals.

The Tata Group and the Tata Trusts have accorded priority to establishing cancer facilities in various Indian states, adopting a 'step-down' model to combating the dreaded disease. This approach has four levels, with fully equipped hospitals at the first and outreach at the last. Many cancer